



GERMANY

Capital city: Berlin

Area: 137,846 sq miles
(357,021 sq km)

Population: 82,500,000

Official language:
GermanMajor religions: Christian
67%, Muslim 3%, other
30%Government: Multiparty
democracy

Currency: Euro

Adult literacy rate: 99%

Life expectancy: 78 years

People per doctor: 303

Televisions: 580 per 1,000
people

GERMANY

LYING AT THE HEART OF EUROPE, Germany is one of the world's wealthiest nations. In its present form, Germany is also one of the newest countries in Europe. After World War II, it was divided into two separate countries – West Germany, a western-style democracy, and East Germany, a communist state. In 1990, the two parts of Germany were reunited as one country. The eastern part is now struggling to overcome the legacy of economic decay and pollution left by its communist past.



EDUCATION

Young German children go to nursery school, then to primary school. At the age of 10, they move to either a *Gymnasium* (junior high school), a *Hauptschule* (secondary school) or a *Realschule* (vocational school). These last two types of schools specialize in training students in technical skills.



RECENT HISTORY

The reunification of Germany took place on October 3, 1990. Growing protests in East Germany, and the collapse of communism in the USSR, finally led the government to make changes. The Berlin Wall, symbol of Germany's division, was demolished, and East Germans started to flood into West Berlin. The city has regained its status once more as the capital of Germany and the seat of government.



FEDERAL STATES

Germany has only been a single country since 1871. Before that, it was divided into many independent states. Today, Germany is still made up of 16 states, or *Länder* (shown left), with a federal system of government, similar to the US. Each *Land* has its own state government and controls local issues such as education. Many Germans still have a strong sense of regional identity, thinking of themselves as Bavarians, for example, first, and Germans second.



Many provincial cities in Germany were formerly the capitals of independent states. Dresden, shown here, is now the capital of Saxony, a region that was once part of the former East Germany.

THE ENVIRONMENT

Thanks to the success of the Green Party, Germans are very aware of the need to protect the environment. There are very strict controls on pollution – Germany has led the way in equipping catalytic converters to cars and in using lead-free gasoline. Most houses have three separate trash cans for different types of waste, so that household garbage can be recycled.



Paper waste is collected separately from people's houses and taken to a refuse site like this one for recycling.

FOOD AND DRINK

The annual Munich *Oktoberfest* is the biggest of the many beer festivals held all over Germany. It lasts for two weeks and attracts millions of beer drinkers. Beer is Germany's national drink, with wine a close second. Popular types of food include bread, pastries, pretzels, cold meats, and cheese. *Wurst* (sausage) is another German specialty. Many regions make their own local sausages.

